

scrutinize them for errors or hidden costs. She spent the same amount of money she always had—“Too much,” she said—but had no idea what her balances were at the end of the month. “Should I sell my house, Kevin, and downsize? Or should I hold on to it?” she asked. Her family was beginning to pester her about the estate. She had two grandchildren in college she wanted to help, and her sister was angling for a loan for a small business. She knew her late husband had had some investments, but she wasn’t sure what they were in and whether they were doing well or not. Mostly, she was worried about the economy and what that would mean to the nest egg she knew her husband had socked away somewhere. My alarm bells went off. I thought about my own wife, Linda. Would she know how to manage our finances if something happened to me? I doubted it.

This woman in Beacon Hill was far from destitute. She had the means, but had never learned anything about how to manage her own personal finances. She was scared and she was alone.

Tears welled in her eyes. If she’d been pitching me on *Shark Tank*, I would have said, “Pull yourself together. Your tears don’t add any value.” In business, money and emotions don’t mix. But this woman wasn’t asking me for money. She wasn’t pitching me an idea. She was asking me for help. And I wanted to give it to her.

I tried to gather a bit more information. “How are you getting your money now?” I asked.

“A check from our investments comes every month as a direct deposit. And then there’s another automatic deposit that arrives in our account once a month—I’m just not sure where it’s coming from. I use my bank card to make withdrawals from our accounts. I’m so embarrassed by how little I know about our finances.”

“Have you talked to your bank manager?”

“Yes, but I don’t really understand what he’s telling me. I’ve never been very good with money, which is why my husband used to take care of things.”

“And why are you asking me for help?”

“I guess because I trust you to tell me the truth.”

I leaned toward her as though delivering the most important information she’d ever receive. “I want you to listen to me very